

FANTASISING CELEBRITIES

Bad Boy, Coy Girl

At first glance, it seems perfect. Salman Khan, the man with the oldest best body in the business, is the one women want to take to their beds. Aishwarya Rai Bachchan and Katrina Kaif, two fair-skinned former models, international enough to impress the world and docile enough to adapt to traditions, are the women men most want. In choosing Salman, women

There is, as filmmaker Paromita Vohra notes, no ambiguity in desiring him. His sexuality is not suspect, his faithfulness lasts at least as long as each monogamous relationship, and his unwavering focus on his love object makes him part of a familiar intimate landscape. As for the women, despite their overt westernisation, their most striking aspect is their sexual coyness. Both Aishwarya, when she was

Which celebrity have you fantasised about?



TOP 5 FOR MEN

Aishwarya Rai Bachchan	5	Salman Khan	3
Katrina Kaif	5	Shah Rukh Khan	1
Sania Mirza	3	John Abraham	1
Priyanka Chopra	3	Aamir Khan	1
Kareena Kapoor	3	Amitabh Bachchan	1

TOP 5 FOR WOMEN

All figures in per cent.

are crying out for the passionate love he embodies. He is part Prem, urbane, naughty, romantic, and part Radhe, obsessive, often violent, lover. He is both a bit of rough and a bit of a softie. Women believe he is a bad boy only so they can reform him.

single, and Katrina now don't flaunt their relationships. They are beautiful without being threatening, smart without being aggressive, and capable without being challenging. They don't want to change the world, merely make it a prettier place.

Women are increasingly receiving signals to "up their sex lives" using a variety of tricks. Young women are being asked that they walk the thin and invisible line that demands that they appear sexually desirable without earning the label slut, and that they remain essentially virtuous Indian women without becoming frumpy aunties. How then can we think of pleasure and fantasy in a world signalled by both increasing demands and apparent danger? So what might be a "safe" space to fantasise even as we inch our way towards becoming the desiring women we imagine we could be? Where can we begin to articulate our fantasies and desires in a forum that is exciting and safe? A tentative and provision-laden response to this might be the Internet.

In an Internet chatroom, I can be anyone. I can devise a new appearance for myself: (much better looking), a new age (younger) and a new persona (sexually adventurous). I can change my occupation, my city, my marital status and even my sex if I like. I can become the conventionally beautiful woman or the macho successful man. Or I can be a "pervert" expressing all kinds of apparently "deviant"

17 PER CENT FROM JAIPUR THINK ABOUT HAVING SEX WITH A MINOR, WHILE 7 PER CENT FROM BANGALORE FANTASISE ABOUT A 50-YEAR-OLD.

desires. I can chat with someone, having become this new person, this figment of my imagination, free to become someone entirely different the next time I'm on the Internet and my desires are different.

Of course, like the street, the Internet is not necessarily a safe space and the potential for pleasure here is equally accompanied by the possibility of danger. But I would argue that for the technologically sophisticated and the carefully anonymous, it does provide the possibility of fantasising in a space where boundaries are much more fluid than on the street. This, of course, is not intended to be the end of the road, for of course what's to stop us from taking that next step—meeting the stranger at the other end of the online connection for coffee and conversation and who knows what else.

This possibility, I argue, is why female desires are so fiercely policed and why we learn to police even our fantasies. For today we might fantasise about strangers and celebrities, tomorrow talk to them on the Internet, the next week view pornography, the next month plan to meet our strangers and from then onwards the fabric of "Indian family life" will never be the same again. The project really is not to find our desires but to legitimise them. For there are those 14 per cent women, and maybe more, who are articulating it already, claiming the right to speak their dangerous desires. To assert that it is not just all right but imperative for us to speak.

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